

subjects like Physical Education, Art and Computer Science, recruitments for which had not been announced initially. If met, this will be the biggest recruitment drive for school teachers in Gujarat in recent memory. The last recruitment was in 2022 when only 2,600 teachers were taken in.

The simmering resentment over the slow pace of teacher recruitments, a longstanding issue in the state, had reached boiling point in June, with thousands of job-seekers gathering in Gandhinagar to protest. The agitation had even turned violent after the police did not allow those arriving in the state capital from different parts of Gujarat to gather at the protest site and forcefully detained some of them.

The target recruitment figure announced by the Gujarat government since may seem massive in itself, but the magnitude of vacancies in primary and secondary schools in the state is bigger. By the state's own admission at the time the recruitments were announced, 39,016 teaching posts have been lying vacant in primary and secondary schools across the state. Which means even if all the promised 24,700 teachers are recruited, there will still be 14,316 unfilled posts.

The real picture, in fact, may be even more grim. According to Yuvrajsinh Jadeja, an exam paper leak scam whistleblower who had been a catalyst in mobilising the teachers' protests, the vacancies are understated because the National Education Policy (NEP) requires the teacher pupil ratio to be 1:25 [in areas having large numbers of socio-economically disadvantaged students] instead of the current 1:30. "With the compounding retirements next year, if the current vacancies are not filled, there will be 1.5 lakh vacancies next year," Jadeja claims. Which is a pity, he adds, because every year, some 250,000 youngsters complete their BEd and a majority of them would prefer a government job.

The issue of teachers recruitment is a complex one, involving not just the subject of employment but also the quality of education in government-run and aided schools. According to those in the know, the government's solution to the vacancies in teaching posts has been to go for 'Gyan Sahayaks', temporary teachers recruited from among those who have cleared TAT and TET. These ad hoc teachers are appointed on 11-month contracts, on an average remuneration of Rs 21,000 per month, but are paid only for the days that they teach, and not on holidays or vacations, unlike full-time teachers, claim sources.

"There is no job guarantee, so we have seen that they typically do not want to be deployed in rural and tribal areas for just a temporary job," says Manish Doshi, chief spokesperson of the Gujarat Congress. That, in turn, exacerbates the vacuum in village government schools, which languish without teachers. "This prompts parents to pull out their children and enrol them in private schools. As student numbers drop, the government shuts down schools in villages," alleges Doshi. The Socio Economic Review 2023-24 released by the state government in February 2024 partly corroborates that, pegging government primary schools at "44,285 in 2022-23 as against 44,492 in 2021-22".

Those in the government claim this is part of a long-term plan to overhaul the school system in the state. A reliable senior source in the government spelt out the rationale to INDIA TODAY thus: "We need school consolidation—that is, the merging of 4,200 small schools (with less than 30 students each) with the nearest bigger schools within one km. We have 15,000-20,000 teachers working in such schools that need to be consolidated. We also need to factor in declining (rural) populations and thus declining net enrolments in government schools before recruiting permanent teachers or making future projections of vacancies."

The protests have come at an inconvenient time for the BJP, given that local body elections are due in 15 months. "There is indeed political pressure," admits a senior BJP leader. "Various teachers' bodies have been protesting since 2017. We deployed political tactics in the past, reaching out through religious and community leaders to calm them, but the Lok Sabha results suggest we are facing significant anti-incumbency."

For those awaiting employment, the July announcement is an "empty promise" till "the notification of recruitment is issued", says Majithiya. If the promised job materialises, it will also bring the hope of a new beginning in other aspects of life for him and many like him. Despite his educational qualifications and his father having a stable farm income, Majithiya says half a dozen prospective brides have rejected him because he is not employed. ■

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